

Lab 2.2: Build a Competitor Profile

Introduction

This hands-on lab gives you practice building a competitor's profile from public information. Using the Competitor Profile Template, you will complete a SWOT analysis and a messaging map for a major competitor, then identify where you can differentiate. The goal is to practice honest, ethical competitive analysis that you can turn into a real selling advantage.

Learning Objectives

After completing this lab, you will be able to:

- Discuss a SWOT analysis for a competitor using public sources.
- Map a competitor's messaging and identify their blind spots.
- Identify positioning gaps you can use to differentiate.



Scenario

You are a competitive strategist at PayPro Solutions. Your main competitor in the mid-market is ADP, a large, well-established payroll and HR provider. Leadership wants a clear profile of ADP, so the sales team knows how to position against them when the two go head-to-head.

Your task is to build a competitor profile for ADP using only public information, their website, marketing, public reviews, and general market knowledge, and to identify where PayPro can win.

Note: Use only publicly available, ethically gathered information. This lab is about fair positioning, not unverified claims. Where you are estimating, mark it as an estimate.

Tools Overview

Competitor Profile Template

The downloadable template from this lesson, with sections for an overview, SWOT analysis, message map, vulnerabilities, and your differentiation.

Resource Files

Competitor Profile Template (DOCX)
Lab 2.2 Exemplar Solution (DOCX)

Instructions

Exercise 1: Complete the SWOT Analysis

Objective: Organize what you know about ADP into strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats.

Step 1: List strengths and weaknesses

Using public knowledge of ADP as a large, established provider, list their genuine strengths (the reasons customers choose them) and their likely weaknesses (the openings for a more right-sized competitor). Be honest about their strengths.

Step 2: Note opportunities and threats

Identify one or two market shifts that could help ADP (opportunities) and one or two forces working against them (threats).

Exercise 2: Map Their Messaging

Objective: Understand how ADP positions itself and what it leaves out.

Step 1: Capture what they emphasize

Based on how a large, established provider typically positions itself, note what ADP emphasizes (for example, scale, brand, breadth of features).

Step 2: Identify the blind spots

Note what their positioning leaves out. What a competitor emphasizes tells you their strength; what they omit points to your opening.

Exercise 3: Find Your Differentiation

Objective: Turn the analysis into a clear point of difference for PayPro.

Step 1: Reframe their strengths

For ADP's biggest strengths, identify the shadow side, the trade-off that comes with that strength, and how PayPro would reframe it for a mid-market buyer.

Step 2: State your sharpest difference

In one sentence, state where PayPro is a better fit than ADP for a mid-market company.

Lab Output/Expected Outcome

By the end of this lab, you should have a completed competitor profile that includes:

- A SWOT analysis for ADP, honesty about strengths and clearness of weaknesses.

- A message map showing what ADP emphasizes and what it leaves out.

A clear differentiation statement for PayPro in the mid-market.

Note: Congratulations. You have built a competitor profile you could actually use in the field. Honest, ethical competitive analysis, naming real strengths and finding their shadow side, is what lets you position with credibility rather than empty claims. Compare your work to the Lab 2.2 Exemplar Solution and note that you will build this profile in Lab 2.3 to create a full battle card.

Summary

A competitor profile is built from public, ethically gathered information. A SWOT analysis organizes a competitor's strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats. Honesty about genuine strengths gives the analysis credibility. A messaging map captures what a competitor emphasizes and what it omits. Omissions in a competitor's messaging reveal openings to exploit. Reframing a competitor's strengths exposes the trade-offs behind them. A single differentiation statement of names where the better fit lies. Estimates are marked clearly to keep claims fair and verifiable.
